

The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

SU V1 V2 V3 V4



Partly sunny 49/31 • Tomorrow: Shower 50/44 **B18**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

WEDNESDAY, DECEMBER 17, 2025 • \$4

U.S. trails, public lands in trouble, report finds

Forest Service document warns of safety problems after Trump's staff cuts

BY HANNAH NATANSON

Trails maintained by the U.S. Forest Service nationwide are being "abandoned" and deteriorating rapidly, threatening visitor safety, after the Trump administration cut staff, according to an internal report obtained by The Washington Post.

The December report finds that some Forest Service districts have lost up to 100 percent of their trail staff under President Donald Trump, departures representing "hundreds of years of trail expertise"; that the remaining staff members are suffering widespread burnout and low morale, leading to "poor customer service"; and that millions of dollars in unspent grant funds have been returned to the agency, often because of vacancies or extra red tape imposed by the Trump administration.

"Many districts are unable to conduct basic trail maintenance ... backcountry trails are being abandoned [and] deferred maintenance is exponentially compounding," the report states. "Compliance issues are rising (e.g., illegal motorized use, user-created routes, trash). The public reports missing trail signage, trees blocking access, bridges in disrepair, and tread erosion."

The report states it is based on the accounts of nearly 300 district-level workers whom the Forest Service interviewed.

SEE FORESTS ON A9

Judge lets ballroom project go on for now

He gives White House 2 weeks to finalize plans for federal review panels

BY DAN DIAMOND AND JONATHAN EDWARDS

A federal judge on Tuesday suggested he would allow the Trump administration to continue work on its controversial ballroom addition, but gave the White House two weeks to file its still-unfinished ballroom plans.

Judge Richard J. Leon said the White House had until the end of December to submit its ballroom plans to a pair of federal review panels. He pressed the administration on whether its current efforts on underground construction would shape the final ballroom, and he expressed skepticism of whether the White House could truly submit plans — which a Justice Department attorney said remain unfinished — in the accelerated timetable.

Leon also warned government lawyers that if the administration performs underground construction that dictates the size of the eventual ballroom, it should be prepared to remove it.

"The court will address it, I assure you of that," Leon said, adding that he expected to decide whether to issue a temporary restraining order.

SEE BALLROOM ON A4



SAUL LOEB/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

The statue of civil rights activist Barbara Rose Johns is unveiled Tuesday at Emancipation Hall. Every state is represented by two statues, and Johns will join George Washington for Virginia. Johns, seen below in a school photo, was 16 when she led the walkout.

Black teen's statue replaces Lee at Capitol

Barbara Rose Johns's 1951 protest of conditions at her Virginia high school helped end segregation

BY GREGORY S. SCHNEIDER AND LAURA MECKLER

The symbolism was hard to miss: In the halls of the U.S. Capitol on Tuesday, the statue of a Black teenager who fought against segregation replaced a Confederate general who fought to preserve slavery.

Barbara Rose Johns was only 16 when she led a walkout in 1951 to protest horrendous conditions at her segregated high

school for Black students in rural Farmville, Virginia. Students complained to the NAACP, and their case went all the way to the Supreme Court, part of the set of cases known as *Brown v. Board of Education* that struck down school segregation.

Tuesday afternoon, a statue of Johns was unveiled at the Capitol to replace one of Confederate Gen. Robert E. Lee that had stood for more than a

century. Every state is represented by two statues in the halls of the Capitol building, and Johns joins George Washington to represent Virginia.

"The Commonwealth of Virginia will now be represented by an actual patriot who embodies the principle of liberty and justice for all, and not a traitor who took up arms against the United States," said House Minority Leader

SEE STATUE ON A6



FAMILY PHOTO

Coast Guard labels swastikas 'potentially divisive'

BY TARA COPP AND MICHELLE BOORSTEIN

The U.S. Coast Guard has allowed a new workplace harassment policy to take effect that downgrades the definition of swastikas and nooses from overt hate symbols to "potentially divisive" despite an uproar over the new language that forced the service's top officer to direct that both would remain prohibited.

The new policy went into effect Monday, according to written correspondence that the Coast Guard provided to Congress this week, a copy of which was reviewed by The Washington Post. The manual is posted online and makes clear that its previous version "is cancelled."

The Post last month was first to report on the Coast Guard's plan to revise its workplace harassment policy. The Trump administration

called the article "false," but within hours of its online publication Nov. 20 the service's acting commandant, Adm. Kevin Lunday, issued a memo forcefully denouncing symbols such as swastikas and nooses, and directing that both remain prohibited. Lunday said at the time that his directive would supersede any other policy language.

It's unclear why the new policy was not revised to align with

Lunday's guidance before the new manual went into effect.

The Department of Homeland Security, which oversees the Coast Guard, did not respond to a request for comment before the online publication of this report. Later Tuesday, a spokeswoman for the agency, Tricia McLaughlin, issued a statement attacking The Post and calling its reporting "pathetic" and "false."

SEE SWASTIKAS ON A4



DAVID RYDER/REUTERS

A deluge in the Pacific Northwest

Tanya Mazingo carries her cat, Mr. Fritz, through floodwaters Tuesday in Pacific, Washington. Days of heavy rain and flooding have inundated communities, forced the evacuations of tens of thousands and prompted scores of rescues. One man was found dead early Tuesday in a submerged car near Seattle.

A show of resilience at Hanukkah celebrations

After Australia attack, U.S. Jewish communities make a point to show up

BY KARIN BRULLIARD, TIM CRAIG AND CAROLINE O'DONOVAN

BOULDER, COLO. — Hundreds of people gathered on the downtown mall of this college town on Monday to watch as three flames on a tall menorah helped illuminate the dark December night.

The occasion was a Hanukkah celebration that has been held annually for nearly three decades. It is a joyful ritual of perseverance that congregations across the country are marking this week. But for members of the Jewish community here, the event felt different this year.

It was a chance to find peace in a space that had been violently

scarred six months before by a deadly firebombing attack on a demonstration supporting Israeli hostages in Gaza. And it was a moment to assert resilience even in the shadow of an antisemitic attack at a similar Hanukkah event in Sydney just one day before.

"Boulder is our home, and we want this space, this block, to be a place of community and joy," Jonathan Lev, executive director of the Boulder Jewish Community Center, told the crowd. He urged them to "look at how a single candle can defy darkness."

That mood — of both reflection and defiance — was echoed over the past couple of days at Hanukkah celebrations across the United States. While the deadly shooting in Australia and a heightened climate of antisemitism prompted many to boost security measures, Jewish leaders and participants from places such as New York, Washington and Minnesota

SEE BOULDER ON A5

IN THE NEWS

Rob Reiner's killing Son Nick Reiner will face two charges of first-degree murder in the stabbings of the famed filmmaker and his wife, photographer Michele Singer Reiner. B1

Supersize data centers Huge facilities are being built to meet AI demand, transforming U.S. communities and landscapes. A8

THE NATION Candace Owens's shocking claims about Charlie Kirk's killing are dividing MAGA. A2
New visuals of a person of interest in the Brown shooting have been released. A7

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A Holocaust survivor died a hero in Sunday's deadly antisemitic attack in Sydney. A11

THE ECONOMY Gas cars are getting a boost as the E.U. and Ford retreat from climate strategies and the EV transition slows. A13
UPS cheated holiday workers out of millions of dollars in pay, according to a lawsuit filed by the New York attorney general. A15

STYLE An antigay slur is having a sudden cultural renaissance. How should we feel about that? B1

SPORTS Americans are increasingly concerned about the influence of the sports gambling industry, a Post-UMD poll has found. B7

THE REGION Maryland lawmakers held a special session Tuesday to elect Joseline A. Peña-Melnyk as House speaker. B13

FOOD Ease the stress from Christmas morning with our make-ahead holiday recipes for sliders, waffles and more.

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